"IN THE BEGINNING..."

GENESIS 26

IN 5 MINUTES

When:

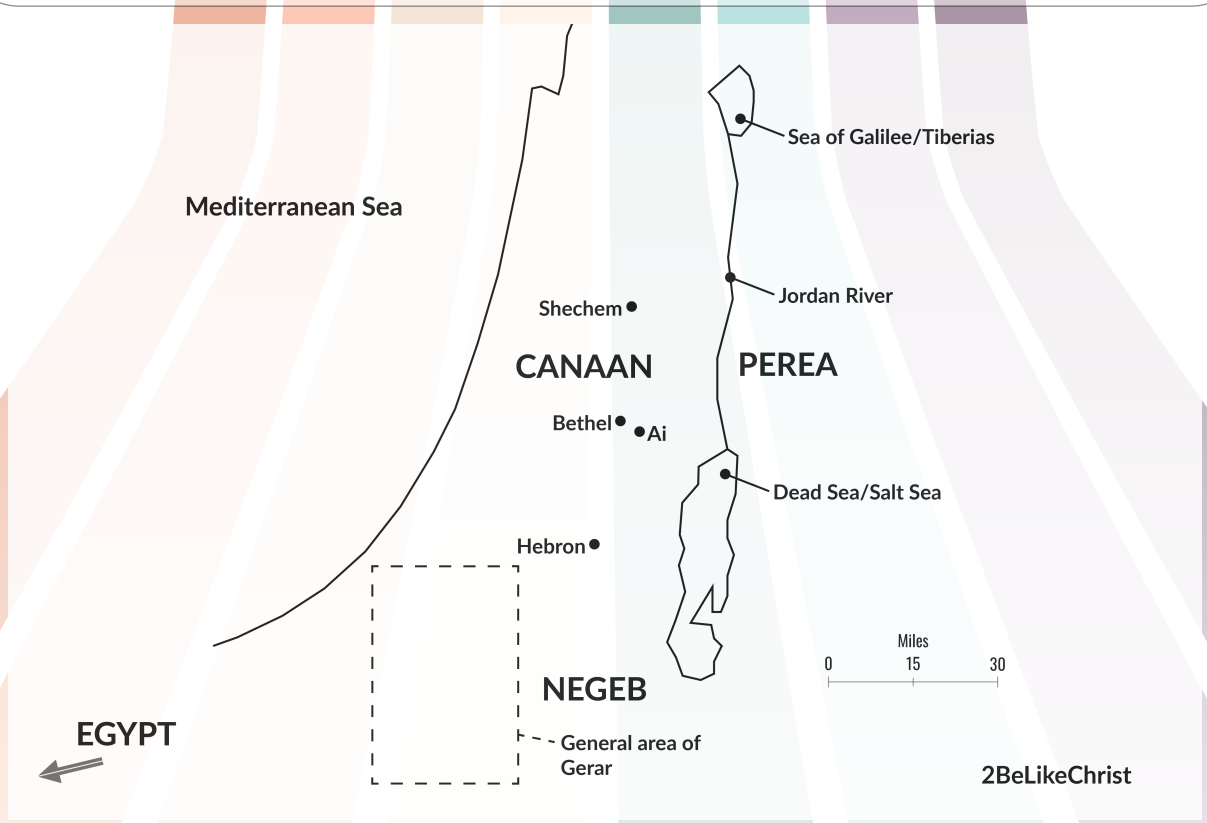
- Isaac was born in approx. 1896 B.C. and married Rachel when he was 40 years old (1856 B.C.). Isaac lived to be 180 years old and died around 1716 B.C. The events recorded in chapter 26 occurred sometime between 1856-1716 B.C., almost certainly towards the beginning of that period.

Characters:

- Isaac – Abraham's son and husband of Rebekah. He was blessed by God and very rich.
- Rebekah – Isaac's wife and mother of Jacob and Esau.
- Abimelech – The ruler of Gerar and king of the Philistines.
- Herdsman of Gerar – They were constantly argued with Isaac over the property rights to the wells his servants dug.

Where:

- In Genesis 26, Isaac's family lived in Gerar before later settling in Beersheba.



Outline:

- GOD'S PROMISES TO ISAAC AND HIS FAMILY (26:1-5):
    + There was a famine in the land of Canaan and God told Isaac not to go down to Egypt, but to dwell in the land He promised to his father Abraham.
    + Isaac was told his offspring would be multiplied like the stars of heaven and in them all the nations of the earth would be blessed.
- ISAAC LIES TO ABIMELECH (26:6-11):
    + Isaac settled in Gerar.
    + He was afraid the men of Gerar would kill him and take his wife, because she was "attractive in appearance", so he lied and told them she was his sister.
    + When Abimelech, the king of the region, discovered Rebekah was actually Isaac's wife, he rebuked Isaac for endangering his people.
    + He threatened his citizens with death if they bothered Isaac or Rebekah.
- DISPUTES ABOUT WATER AND WELLS (26:12-25):
    + Isaac was blessed by the Lord and became very rich.
    + He was so rich and powerful that Abimelech asked him to leave Gerar.
    + He settled in the Valley of Gerar and his servants dug a well for water.
    + When they finished the well, the herdsmen of Gerar bickered with Isaac's servants because they wanted the well for themselves.
    + The servants proceeded to dig another well, but the herdsmen bickered over that one too.
    + Isaac's household moved on and dug a 3rd well, and on this 3rd attempt the herdsmen left them alone.
    + Isaac then moved to Beersheba and erected an altar to the Lord.
- ISAAC AND ABIMELECH MAKE A TREATY (26:26-33):
    + Abimelech recognized how the Lord was blessing Isaac and he proposed a treaty of peace between Isaac's household and his own.
    + Isaac made a feast, and in the morning the two parties exchanged oaths.
- ESAU'S WIVES (26:34-35):
    + When Esau was 40 years old, he married two Hittite women, Judith and Basemath.
    +z Their union "made life bitter for Isaac and Rebekah."

Application:

- Abraham and Isaac's story is like our own in many ways.
- They were constantly travelling from place to place as nomads as they waited for the Lord to fulfill His promise to give them a land of their own.
- "By faith [Abraham] went to live in the land of promise, as in a foreign land, living in tents with Isaac and Jacob, heirs with him of the same promise (Hebrews 11:9).
- There is a sense in which Christians are pilgrims and nomads. We sojourn on earth for a time in anticipation of the permanent home God has promised us in heaven.
- It will be a great day when we finally get to put our luggage and burdens down in the place we will call home for eternity.